Diki Tsering woke very early on July 6, 1935. She went out behind her mud-and-stone house in Taktser, Tibet, to the barn. There, among the animals, she gave birth to her son Lhamo (say: LAM-oh). He didn't cry. His eyes were open wide. Lhamo's mother, Diki, and father, Choekyong Tsering, already had four children—their daughter, Dolma, and three sons named Norbu, Gyalo, and Lobsang. There wasn't much furniture in their six-room house. The children didn't have their own beds. The family mostly gathered in the kitchen, especially during cold Tibetan winters, to keep warm by the fire. They practiced Tibetan Buddhism, a religion that was very important to them and to all Tibetans. So their house also had a prayer room, where the family left offerings of food and flowers at a small altar.



Taktser, a small village in the northeastern province of Amdo, was on a hill with a view of a wide valley. The land and the weather weren't good for